Architectures of Absence: AI Governance under the FS AI RMF

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Abstract

The Financial Services AI Risk Management Framework (FS AI RMF) gives community banks 230 control objectives but not a common language for deciding what their artifacts establish. Banks may also depend on vendor systems they are responsible for governing but cannot unilaterally change. This position paper offers a translation ontology for coordination among banks, examiners and regulators, and vendors and architects, with affected parties as its normative center. *Empty-chair representation* asks whose interest a control protects when that party is absent from an AI-supported decision.

The ontology follows an affected interest through control objective, evidentiary object, available artifact, claimed inference and binding, and the actor able to close, disclose, or contest a gap. Decision records, feature attributions, local approximations, generated rationales, human review records, and approvals expose different objects; none inherits another's warrant merely by being called an explanation. The *evidentiary-substitution sequence* names that structure neutrally; *silence-manufacture* names instances in which unavailable contradictory evidence helps an unsupported substitution persist.

Three two-layer diagnostics first orient inquiry and then structure any authorized evidence request: empty-chair enumeration, pages missing from the ledger relative to a declared attestation scope, and the produced-silence question pair. They motivate five provisional evidentiary capabilities: revision-aware temporal capture; evidence binding and exportability; non-collapsing uncertainty representation; technical-change monitoring; and institutional-conformance monitoring. Worked applications to selected FS AI RMF controls illustrate the vocabulary rather than validate it across the framework. The paper supplies neither an implementation validation nor new examination authority; it identifies where current claims, technical capabilities, institutional obligations, and policy choices should meet.

1 Opening Movement

The Financial Services AI Risk Management Framework (FS AI RMF), developed by the Cyber Risk Institute with the Financial Services Sector Coordinating Council and the US Treasury and released in February 2026, specifies 230 control objectives spanning governance, data, model development, validation, monitoring, third-party risk, and consumer protection (U.S. Department of the Treasury 2026). Read as a checklist, the framework is operationally daunting and conceptually opaque:

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community banks still face the question of what *commensurate* compliance means, and the document itself does not answer it. The FS AI RMF, unlike the supervisory model-risk guidance issued the same year (SR Letter 26-2), has no asset-size threshold; it is designed to apply to all financial institutions regardless of size, type, complexity, or criticality. Read as a structure, however, the framework admits an organizing lens: many control objectives can be understood as protecting an interest of a party who is not in the room when an AI system makes or supports a financial decision. We develop empty-chair representation as an interpretive lens and apply it to selected controls rather than assert a coding of all 230 objectives. Whether the reading holds framework-wide remains an empirical question.

Recent commentary on the FS AI RMF describes it as a *systems blueprint* rather than a checklist, and urges institutions to map controls to architecture, ownership, and evidence rather than to documentation alone (Mushahwar and Rippe 2026). We extend that move one step further: the blueprint has a normative structure, and that structure is *empty-chair representation*: the design of AI governance such that specific absent parties are structurally represented in the architecture of decision-making, not merely in its documentation.

The party in the empty chair varies by control. It may be a loan applicant seeking recourse, a depositor, a future compliance officer inheriting an unfamiliar system, an examiner applying later guidance, or the institution after personnel and ownership changes. The empty chair is plural, and the interests do not always agree. Affected parties are the normative center of the inquiry even though they do not possess power symmetric with institutions, vendors, or the state. The proposed function of governance architecture is to make their interests inspectable by those acting at decision time and by those who later review or contest the decision. Inspectable representation is not the same as direct access to an artifact, participation in the decision process, or an authorized remedy. None follows automatically from the others or from this ontology.

This paper is therefore a coordination device, not an instruction manual for any one participant. Its translation ontology follows a claim across institutional boundaries: from an *affected interest*, to a *control objective*, to the *evidentiary object* needed to test that objective; then to the *artifact* actually available, the *inference* claimed from it and the *binding* offered between them; and finally to the actor with the authority, capability, obligation, or standing to close, disclose, or contest any gap. These terms separate questions that are often collapsed. An actor may be obligated to produce evidence without possessing the technical capability to generate it; an examiner may identify an unsupported inference without authority to prescribe a particular architecture; and an affected party may have the strongest interest in a contest without access to the relevant artifact.

A note on provenance bounds the claim of novelty. Stakeholder theory, value-sensitive design, agency theory, organizational decoupling, audit scholarship, and assurance-case reasoning already explain affected interests, costly monitoring, ceremonial substitution, and structured claim–evidence–warrant argument (Freeman 1984; Friedman 1996; Jensen and Meckling 1976; Meyer and Rowan 1977; Power 1997; Bloomfield and Bishop 2010); this paper does not rediscover them. Its narrower contribution is the connecting sequence in the FS AI RMF setting — from an affected interest to the control objective, required evidentiary object, offered artifact, claimed inference and binding, and the actor able to act on the gap — and Section 4 positions that sequence against each of those traditions in full.

The intended pathway is reciprocal but not symmetrical, and it operates at two levels. One bank can inventory its evidence dependencies, narrow claims to what available artifacts warrant, use proportionate compensating processes where they exist, disclose residual limitations, and make procurement needs comparable. Examiners can test institutional claims under existing authority. Cross-vendor bindings, standard exports, convergent supervisory expectations, and market leverage require collective action by regulators, trade groups, vendors, or multiple institutions; an individual

community bank cannot create them by responsible procurement alone. Affected parties supply the reason those activities matter and, where law or process permits, evidence with which institutional accounts may be contested. Neutrality here is procedural, not viewless: each perspective receives standing, unequal power remains visible, and no participant's preferred inference is insulated from challenge.

This reframe matters operationally. By *verification regime* we mean the set of technical, procedural, and evidentiary mechanisms by which a party not present at the moment of decision can later test a material claim about that decision, rather than accept the claim from the outcome or from an institution's assertion. A control *represents* an absent party when it induces observable, auditable constraints on system behavior or evidence production that an authorized recipient can use to assess whether that party's interests were respected. Representation in this sense is architectural; documentation can participate in it, but an assertion of representation is not evidence that representation occurred. Whether the affected party can inspect, challenge, participate, or obtain relief depends on law and institutional process outside the ontology.

The object being verified must be named. A decision record may preserve the *inputs and context* available at decision time. SHAP can characterize *functional feature dependence* under a specified value function and background construction; LIME can provide a *local behavioral approximation* under a specified neighborhood and surrogate (Lundberg and Lee 2017; Ribeiro et al. 2016). Attention and activation analyses expose selected *internal computational states*, although attention weight alone does not establish feature importance (Jain and Wallace 2019). Chain-of-thought and other natural-language accounts are *generated rationales*. A contemporaneous reviewer record is evidence about a *human deliberative record*: what was presented, consulted, recorded, and decided, not transparent access to every cognitive process. A signature or approval log records *institutional authorization and review*. These artifacts can each be useful. They are not interchangeable, and an artifact may faithfully establish one object without establishing another.

This distinction changes the examination question. The question is not simply whether the institution has produced an explanation. It is *what evidentiary object does this artifact expose, what conclusion is the recipient being asked to draw from it, and what binds the artifact to that conclusion?* A local approximation may illuminate behavior without recording deliberation; an understandable rationale may communicate a decision without faithfully characterizing functional dependence; a signature may establish authorization without establishing the truth of the material reviewed. Verification fails when the claimed conclusion requires a different object from the one the architecture exposes.

Examiners reviewing AI deployments at community banks face a problem the framework does not solve for them: 230 control objectives do not themselves specify how documentary evidence warrants a conclusion about deployed behavior. With an empty-chair frame, examination becomes a structured inquiry: *which absent parties does this AI system affect, what artifact represents their interests, and what conclusion can that artifact support?* The frame supplements the checklist with an evidentiary question.

Two positions follow. First, *an explanation artifact is not, by itself, a verification regime for a different evidentiary object.* Post-hoc methods have legitimate uses, including model diagnosis, communication, and exploration; their limits depend on their target and construction (Oh 2024). But in adversarial review the recipient cannot assume that an understandable artifact establishes a different proposition without an inspectable binding between them (Bordt et al. 2022). SHAP and LIME can be manipulated in ways that conceal objectionable model behavior (Slack et al. 2020); generated chain-of-thought can be unfaithful to the computation that produced an answer (Lanham et al. 2023; Turpin et al. 2023). These findings concern different artifacts and mechanisms. Their common governance lesson is narrower: the institution must establish the warrant for the inference

it asks the examiner or affected party to draw.

Second, *review of an explanation verifies that the explanation was reviewed; it does not by itself verify a decision process that the explanation does not faithfully represent.* A signature can establish authorization, responsibility, and completion of a specified procedure. Those are real governance functions. If the institution also claims that the signature establishes the substantive basis of an AI recommendation, it must show what the reviewer could inspect, what independent judgment the procedure required, and how the reviewed artifact bears on that substantive claim. Human presence in a workflow and verification of a model-supported decision are not equivalent propositions.

These positions do not counsel against AI in banking. They distinguish uses by the evidentiary claim the architecture must support. Pattern recognition, anomaly detection, and consistency monitoring can surface material for investigation while leaving the disposition and its documented basis with an authorized human. Decision-recommendation systems may demand evidence about model behavior, data, policy fit, human review, and the relation among them. The difference is not captured by a generic "human in the loop" label or a generic explanation requirement; it depends on which party decides, which artifact is exposed, and which conclusion that artifact can support.

A note on what the empty-chair frame is doing structurally, before the body sections develop it. Absence in regulated decision contexts is not always a static gap. An interface may make challenge costly; a documentation regime may preserve only later justification; a metric may omit the evidence needed to test the conclusion drawn from it. The frame therefore asks not only *who is absent* but *what access does the architecture remove, what artifact replaces it, and what inference is drawn from the replacement?* Section 4 develops this recurring inference gap as silence-manufacture. The claim is conditional: silence is not evidence of absence when the system being evaluated materially contributes to that silence.

The remainder of this paper applies the lens to specific FS AI RMF control objectives, develops three diagnostic questions, and proposes provisional evidentiary capabilities at the property level. Its test is practical: whether the shared vocabulary helps banks, examiners, regulators, vendors, and affected parties locate an evidence gap, identify who can act on it, and distinguish the object an artifact exposes from the broader conclusion placed upon it.

2 The Frame as Method

The empty-chair frame's value depends on whether it provides interpretive leverage on specific controls: vocabulary for what a control is for, criteria for assessing whom an implementation represents, and diagnostic moves for reviewing it. This section offers a worked application in BSA/AML transaction monitoring and, in doing so, distinguishes two kinds of absence.

We choose BSA/AML rather than lending or underwriting deliberately. Lending is where the empty-chair frame is most obvious: the loan applicant is concrete, the harm is concrete, fair-lending controls have decades of regulatory history to draw on, and the absent party's interest is well-rehearsed. The frame applied to lending tends to confirm what readers already believe, which is a poor test of whether the frame is doing work or merely renaming work that was already being done. BSA/AML is harder. The empty chairs are plural and conflicting in ways lending is not. The institution's interest is more aligned with the regulator's than in lending. The customer's interest is ambiguous: protection from fraud and protection from false flagging point in opposite operational directions. If the frame produces clarity here, where the chairs disagree and the controls do not align cleanly with any single absent party, the frame is doing more than renaming.

2.1 Two kinds of absence

Before enumerating the empty chairs in BSA/AML, we refine the frame. The opening movement treated absence as a single category: parties not in the room when a decision is made. In practice, absence has two structurally distinct forms, and the diagnostic moves available to address them differ.

Structural absence describes parties whose absence is given by the situation: parties who do not yet exist, who have no embodied agent, or whose absence is a designed feature of the regulatory regime. The future compliance officer, the not-yet-victimized customer, the financial system as such, the criminal we are designing to exclude: these are absent because the architecture of the situation places them outside the decision context. The frame's diagnostic move on structural absence is *how does the architecture make this party audible to the parties who are present?*

Produced absence is a hypothesis that a design, cost, rule, interface, or institutional practice materially changes what can be observed, and that a subsequent institutional inference relies on the resulting record. Administrative-burden research already explains how learning, compliance, and psychological costs shape citizen–state interactions (Moynihan et al. 2015); the narrower question here is whether a governance claim relies on the record left after comparable frictions operate. Possible cases include a customer deterred by an expensive appeal, a borrower no longer visible in application data after repeated denial, or a reviewer record limited to later justification. Observed silence is consistent with produced absence but does not establish it. Support requires evidence about the proposed production mechanism: for example, cross-channel or cross-time comparisons, behavior after a material change in friction, user research or complaints, examiner-selected samples, a feasible counterfactual design, or provenance showing which records were excluded or overwritten.

The distinction matters because produced absence is invisible to the empty-chair frame as initially stated. *Make the absent party audible* is inadequate when a system or process may be suppressing the evidence by which the party could be heard. The diagnostic move is therefore conditional: *what feature may be changing observability, who draws an inference from the resulting record, and what evidence would distinguish production from ordinary non-observation?* Unchanged challenge behavior after a material reduction in friction, complete and representative records despite the alleged mechanism, or stable conclusions after previously unavailable evidence becomes accessible would count against a produced-absence account.

This distinction sharpens the paper's first position without presuming causation or bad faith. Compliance theater may fail to represent structural absences; it may also persist through practices that suppress challenge and institutional processes that treat the resulting record as reassuring. The produced-absence hypothesis asks whether that second mechanism is present and what observation could defeat the claim.

2.2 The empty chairs in BSA/AML monitoring

Six absent parties have interests in how a community bank monitors transactions for suspicious activity (Federal Financial Institutions Examination Council 2020). Each is structural, produced, or both. We mark which.

The next victim of fraud whose pattern this transaction is part of. Structural absence. When a transaction is part of an emerging fraud pattern, the institution's monitoring decision affects not the customer making the transaction but the customer who will be victimized in the next iteration. The next victim is fully absent from the transaction record and from the institution's customer relationship by the structure of time and the limits of prediction. They are represented in the monitoring architecture or they are not represented at all.

The customer whose account is frozen on a false positive. Potentially mixed. The customer is present in the transaction record but absent from the decision context that determined how their pattern was scored; that absence is structural. If appeal is opaque, expensive, or slow, the case also raises a produced-absence question: does procedural friction reduce challenges, and does the institution use a challenge-dependent measure as evidence of flagging accuracy? Complaint evidence, cross-channel sampling, or outcomes after reduced friction could test that proposition.

The marginalized customer whose transaction patterns are flagged at elevated rates. Potentially mixed. Models trained on historical SAR data may inherit differences in past enforcement and reporting (U.S. Department of the Treasury 2023). Communities whose transaction patterns differ from the training distribution may therefore be poorly represented. A produced-absence hypothesis requires an additional showing: that differential access to challenge changes the evidence the institution observes and that the institution relies on that censored evidence. Representative outcome sampling or comparison after access changes could support or defeat that claim.

The institution itself, in the form of its future enforcement exposure. Structural absence. The bank that fails to file required SARs faces regulatory action; the bank that over-files faces examiner skepticism about its risk calibration. Both are forms of enforcement exposure that compound over time. The institution's future self — the bank in five years, when current monitoring decisions become the subject of an examination — is an empty chair the present institution can either represent through architectural attestation or fail to represent through reliance on reconstructed reasoning.

The financial system, in the form of monitoring quality across institutions. Structural absence. BSA/AML is a coordinated regulatory regime; one institution's monitoring inadequacy creates externalities for institutions whose monitoring is more rigorous, because illicit activity predictably gravitates toward weaker control environments. The system as a whole is an empty chair represented by inter-agency information sharing, FinCEN reporting, and cross-institution examination practice. The community bank's monitoring architecture either contributes to this representation or free-rides on it.

The criminal whose laundering depends on monitoring inadequacy. Structural absence by intentional design. We name this chair because "do not represent the criminal's interest" is different from "do not represent the criminal in the threat model." Behavior alone may not distinguish a criminal from a marginalized customer. Where costly challenge suppresses corrective evidence and an institutional process treats non-challenge as confirmation, the boundary raises a particularly consequential produced-absence hypothesis.

The 230 control objectives do not generally describe controls in these terms. They specify governance outcomes for AI systems — inventory attributes, oversight mechanisms, explanation practices, monitoring processes — without naming every party whose interest an implementation might protect, and without distinguishing structural from produced absence. The empty-chair frame's first contribution is a vocabulary for examining those implementation choices: which chairs a control objective can represent, which chairs a particular implementation actually represents, and whether any remaining absence is given by the setting or produced by the implementation itself.

2.3 Walking three examples through the frame

The examples below apply four cross-sector FS AI RMF objectives to a community bank's BSA/AML transaction-monitoring system. They are not BSA/AML-specific requirements. For each example, we distinguish the objective's text from its implementation guidance and example evidence, and both from the bank implementation we ask the reader to consider. This distinction matters: an objective can support several implementations, and an implementation may support inferences the

objective neither requires nor warrants. The objective identifiers and descriptions below are from the full Control Objective Reference Guide, version 1.0 (Financial Services Sector Coordinating Council FS AI RMF Workstream and Cyber Risk Institute 2026).

Inventory: GV-1.6.1, AI Inventory Management. The objective requires a regularly updated inventory of AI systems that includes purpose, data sources, responsible personnel, risk ratings, criticality, dependencies, compliance requirements, and decommissioning attributes. Its implementation guidance recommends a standardized template, assigned maintenance responsibility, periodic or trigger-based review, and access controls. Its examples of effective evidence include inventory records, ownership details, change histories, and audit trails.

Applied to transaction monitoring, a current inventory entry establishes something important: the institution has identified the system, assigned responsibility, and recorded specified lifecycle and risk attributes. It allows a future compliance officer or examiner to locate the system in the institution's governance landscape. It does not, by itself, establish that the listed data sources represent affected populations adequately, that the documented purpose matches operational use, or that a particular alert was well founded. Those are different propositions requiring different evidence.

The empty-chair question reveals the difference. The inventory directly represents the institution's future self and the future compliance officer by preserving organizational location and responsibility. It represents a customer affected by an alert only indirectly, through attributes that make later inquiry possible. A bank that treats the existence of a complete inventory entry as evidence that individual outputs are justified has asked the inventory to establish more than it can. Closing that gap requires evidence linked to the deployed system and the decision under review: the operative model version, relevant input lineage, validation results, and the record of how the output entered the decision process. The inventory is the index into that evidence, not a substitute for it.

Human oversight: GV-3.2.2, Monitoring Human-AI Oversight. The objective requires mechanisms such as audits, performance evaluations, and feedback loops to assess human–AI interactions, including automation complacency and inappropriate overreliance. Its guidance asks institutions to examine how well operators detect issues, respond to alerts, and understand system limitations. Its examples include interaction audits, operator evaluations, feedback mechanisms, training, and ongoing assessment of oversight quality.

In a transaction-monitoring implementation, completed audits and operator evaluations establish that the institution examined specified aspects of human oversight. Measures of response quality, override patterns, or detected errors can show whether reviewers are engaging with alerts rather than merely accepting them. But a signed review record establishes only that a reviewer performed the recorded act under the institution's procedure. It does not, without further evidence, establish that the alert was substantively correct or that the reviewer independently evaluated every consideration material to the disposition.

This distinction serves both the falsely flagged customer and the next potential victim. For the former, a review signature is not evidence that the alert's basis was sound. For the latter, an override is not evidence that the reviewer noticed every risk the system surfaced. An implementation can narrow the gap by preserving what information was presented, what sources the reviewer consulted, whether the reviewer accepted or changed the recommended disposition, and which uncertainty or evidence triggered that action. Even this contemporaneous record has limits: it documents observable review activity, not unmediated access to the reviewer's mental process. The objective asks whether human oversight is effective; the implementation must specify which evidence makes that effectiveness assessable.

Explanation and decision context: MS-2.9.1, Model Explainability and Validation, and MS-2.9.2, Interpretability and Decision Context. MS-2.9.1 calls for structured model explanations covering

matters such as design choices, training-data sources, feature importance, and decision pathways, together with validation for stability, fairness, performance, bias, and limitations. Its example controls expressly include interpretable models and post-hoc tools such as SHAP and LIME, with documentation of methods, parameters, assumptions, and limitations. MS-2.9.2 requires outputs and decision rationales to be interpreted for their use context and intended audience. Its guidance and examples emphasize clarity, accessibility, human review, feedback, and testing the usefulness of explanations.

These objectives recognize several legitimate evidentiary functions. Model documentation can establish declared design choices and training sources. Validation can establish measured performance under specified tests. A SHAP or LIME report can characterize aspects of model behavior under the method's construction. User testing can establish whether an intended audience finds an explanation understandable. None of these results automatically establishes the others. In particular, clarity to a reviewer is not evidence that an explanation faithfully represents every computational dependency material to an output, and a technically faithful attribution is not evidence that the attributed model behavior is lawful or policy-conforming.

The empty-chair reading therefore asks which proposition matters to the affected party. A customer challenging a false alert may need to know which evidence supported the institution's action and whether that evidence was applied consistently with policy. An examiner may need to know the model's measured behavior across populations and whether the explanation procedure is stable under relevant conditions. A reviewer may need an account calibrated to the decision they are authorized to make. Treating one explanation artifact as satisfying all three needs produces a gap precisely where the objectives invite contextual implementation. Closing or disclosing that gap requires the institution to name the artifact, the proposition it supports, the method and assumptions that produced it, and the additional evidence needed for any broader inference.

2.4 What the frame produced

Four moves emerge from this worked application. First, it accounts for absent interests in BSA/AML monitoring, including the actor the system is designed to exclude. Second, it distinguishes structural absence from a testable produced-absence hypothesis. Third, it separates objective text, implementation evidence, and further inference. Fourth, it adds a diagnostic pair to the compliance question: *which empty chair does this implementation represent, and could a feature of the system be changing what evidence becomes observable?*

These are not solutions to the problems the objectives address. They are a frame for interpreting the objectives and testing what their implementations establish. The frame's claim to organizing-principle status rests on whether moves of this kind generalize across controls and regulated decision contexts, which the remainder of this paper develops. What this section establishes is narrower: the frame makes visible a distinction among the required governance outcome, the artifact offered as evidence, and the conclusion drawn from that artifact. The structural-versus-produced distinction then asks why any missing evidence is absent and whose interests bear the consequence.

3 Verification Regimes as Taxonomic Move

Section 2 showed that the empty-chair frame separates a governance objective, the artifact offered as evidence, and the conclusion drawn from that artifact. This section applies that distinction to consumer lending. AI applications in regulated decision contexts differ structurally according to the claims their verification regimes can support: which evidentiary objects the architecture exposes, how those objects bind to the decision, and what an affected party or examiner can test.

The worked example is the adverse action notice regime under the Equal Credit Opportunity Act and Regulation B. The notice communicates specific reasons for a denial to an applicant who was absent from the decision but is legally entitled to an account of it. That function creates a precise verification question: what does the notice establish about the basis of the creditor's action, and what evidence allows the applicant or an examiner to test that relationship?

3.1 The structural line

Recall the opening's framing: a verification regime lets a party test a material claim about a decision. Seven evidentiary objects recur in AI-supported workflows. Decision records preserve *inputs and context*. SHAP can characterize *functional feature dependence* under its value-function and background construction. LIME offers a *local behavioral approximation* under its perturbation and surrogate choices (Lundberg and Lee 2017; Ribeiro et al. 2016). Attention or activation analyses expose selected *internal computational states* (Jain and Wallace 2019). Chain-of-thought and other natural-language accounts are *generated rationales*. Contemporaneous workflow records preserve observable parts of a *human deliberative record*. Signatures and approval logs establish *institutional authorization and review*. A system may expose several of these objects, but none acquires the evidentiary function of another merely because both are called explanations.

The methods therefore require method-specific readings. SHAP attributes an output under a specified construction; it does not by itself recover a human deliberative record or prove a complete causal account of model-internal computation. LIME approximates behavior locally, with a warrant bounded by its neighborhood and surrogate. An attention map exposes selected internal quantities, but attention weight alone is not a complete account of computational causation. Generated chain-of-thought is text whose faithfulness must be tested rather than assumed (Lanham et al. 2023; Turpin et al. 2023). An ante-hoc interpretable model can expose its decision function more directly, while leaving separate questions about data provenance, policy validity, and deployment. A contemporaneous human record can show what was presented, consulted, recorded, and decided, but not every cognitive process. An institutional attestation proves that an authorized actor made a recorded commitment; whether the attested content is true depends on its evidence.

This taxonomy yields a structural line, but not a division between "explanations" and "no explanations." An artifact cannot, by itself, verify a proposition about a different evidentiary object. Additional detail of the same kind does not close that gap. The gap closes when the architecture supplies an inspectable relation among the decision, the relevant object, the method that produced the artifact, and the proposition being tested. Section 6 develops provisional capabilities for preserving and inspecting those relations. It does not promise transparent access to an anthropomorphic "model reasoning" object.

3.2 Adverse action notices as the canonical case

The Equal Credit Opportunity Act requires creditors to provide adverse action notices to applicants who are denied credit, stating the specific reasons for the denial (Consumer Financial Protection Bureau 2024). The Fair Credit Reporting Act extends this to credit-based denials more broadly (Federal Trade Commission 2026). The regulatory intent is straightforward: a customer denied credit is entitled to know why, both to enable challenge of the denial and to inform the customer's understanding of their own creditworthiness. The empty chair the regime addresses is the denied applicant.

For a rule-based or low-dimensional scorecard, an institution may be able to trace a denial directly to the operative rule, threshold, input, and policy provision. Complexity changes the

evidence problem, but it does not make every adverse action notice derived from a complex model unfaithful. Institutions may use feature attribution, local approximation, counterfactual analysis, model-specific decision paths, or combinations of methods. The CFPB does not permit complexity to excuse inaccurate or non-specific reasons (Consumer Financial Protection Bureau 2022); the creditor must determine which method supports the reasons it communicates.

The notice itself establishes that the creditor communicated stated reasons. A method record can establish how those reasons were generated. Validation evidence can establish how the method behaved under specified tests. The further proposition — that the communicated reasons accurately identify the factors material to this creditor's action on this application — depends on the relation among those artifacts. Understandability is relevant but not sufficient; method fidelity is relevant but not sufficient; a plausible list is not the same as a tested binding to the action.

The empty-chair reading makes the evidentiary sequence visible. The applicant receives a legally required artifact. Their interest is represented substantively when the creditor can show why the artifact supports the proposition the law requires and when the applicant or examiner has a tractable way to challenge that showing. The frame does not declare every post-hoc method inadequate for every purpose. It asks the institution to name the purpose, the artifact, its warrant, and its limits.

The produced-absence dimension raises a further, testable question. Where reasons are generic or challenge is difficult, does procedural friction reduce the corrective evidence applicants provide, and does the creditor rely on that censored record when assessing notice adequacy? A notice's existence does not answer that question. Cross-channel complaint evidence, examiner-selected files, or changes in challenge behavior after a material reduction in friction could support or defeat the hypothesis. It should not be inferred from non-challenge alone.

3.3 The taxonomic move

The taxonomy divides applications by the verification claim their architecture can support.

AI that surfaces material for an independently accountable disposition. Pattern recognition can surface applications for investigation; anomaly detection can flag unusual facts; consistency monitoring can identify departures from institutional norms. If an authorized reviewer receives the information and authority needed to make the disposition, the institution can preserve the decision inputs and context, the reviewer's observable actions, the recorded basis for the disposition, and the authorization. This does not make the human record infallible or expose every cognitive process. It produces an accountable institutional decision whose evidentiary components can be inspected.

AI that supplies the disposition and an account of it. An underwriting model may generate a recommendation or decision, an explanation method may generate principal reasons, and a human may approve the result. This architecture is not unverifiable merely because it uses AI or a post-hoc method. Its burden is different: the institution must validate the method appropriate to its target, bind the resulting artifact to the operative model and case, define what the human review establishes, and preserve evidence for the broader substantive claim. A signature cannot supply a missing method-to-decision binding; nor does the presence of an explanation make such a binding impossible.

These are architecturally different, not simply points on a risk scale. The first locates the disposition and its recorded basis in an authorized human process supported by AI. The second locates material parts of the disposition in a model-supported process and therefore requires evidence across model behavior, explanation method, case context, policy, and review. "Authority to override" answers who may intervene. It does not answer what the reviewer could test, whether independent judgment was exercised, or what the approval establishes.

3.4 What the categoricals foreclose, and what they do not

The structural line forecloses specific *claims*, not entire model classes. The following claims are not established without additional binding evidence:

- That an adverse action notice is faithful to the creditor's action solely because a post-hoc method generated plausible principal reasons and a human approved the notice.
- That a decision-recommendation workflow received substantive human verification solely because an authorized reviewer signed or had formal override power.
- That a retrospective justification reconstructs the decision-time information and deliberative record solely because no contradictory contemporaneous record exists.

The structural line permits stronger claims where the corresponding evidence is present, including:

- Ante-hoc interpretable models whose operative decision function, inputs, thresholds, and policy relationship are available for inspection, with separate validation of provenance and deployment.
- Decision-support tools where AI surfaces material, an authorized human makes the disposition, and the architecture preserves the information presented, observable review activity, recorded basis, and authorization.
- Model-supported decision architectures that validate an explanation method for its stated target, bind its output to the operative model and case, document its assumptions and limits, and preserve the other evidence needed for the substantive claim under review.

3.5 A turn: pricing as a potential policy and design gap

Adverse-action law supplies an artifact and a proposition it must support. Risk-based pricing in consumer lending — the interest rate, fees, and terms offered to an *approved* applicant — illustrates a different case: a potential policy and design gap. Existing law requires important disclosures in covered circumstances, but it does not generally create an individualized substantive reason-giving regime for the precise price offered that is equivalent to Regulation B's specific-reasons regime for adverse action.

Regulation Z requires standardized cost and term disclosures, including applicable annual-percentage-rate, finance-charge, and payment information (Consumer Financial Protection Bureau 2026b). Subject to exceptions and alternative credit-score disclosures, Regulation V also requires a risk-based pricing notice when a consumer report contributes to granting covered consumer credit on materially less favorable terms than those available to a substantial proportion of the creditor's consumers (Consumer Financial Protection Bureau 2026a). These notices communicate consequential facts, but generally not an individualized substantive account of why this applicant received this exact price.

The evidentiary gap is therefore more diffuse than in denial. The price is communicated as an offer rather than a reasoned determination, and information asymmetries may constrain comparison or negotiation (Bartlett et al. 2022). Acceptance establishes agreement to the offered terms; it does not, without more, establish that the price was substantively justified or fair.

This configuration raises, but does not establish, a produced-absence hypothesis at architectural scale: do the absence of a justification channel, the cost of obtaining comparable offers, or expectations

about negotiability suppress evidence of disagreement, and do institutional assessments then treat acceptance or non-complaint as evidence of fairness? Comparable-offer research, customer studies, complaint records, and behavior after disclosure or friction changes could test the mechanism.

The frame's diagnostic move follows Section 2: *what feature may be changing observability, which institutional actor draws an inference from the resulting record, and what comparison would test the proposed mechanism?*

The diagnostic asks who makes those inferences, from which population, and with what denominator. Accepted applicants are observed; those who decline or never apply may be observed incompletely or not at all. That selection can limit a fairness claim without proving that the institution actually made or relied on the stronger inference.

Pricing models are also subject to important aggregate validation: default outcomes by tier, fair-lending analysis, and ongoing monitoring (Board of Governors of the Federal Reserve System and Office of the Comptroller of the Currency 2011; Board of Governors of the Federal Reserve System 2026). Such evidence can support population-level performance and compliance claims under its stated design; it need not prove an individualized proposition about why a particular customer received a particular price. Conversely, failure to provide that individualized account is not generally, by itself, a basis for an examiner to cite a bank beyond applicable law and supervisory authority. The frame exposes an aggregate–individual distinction for policy discussion. Whether regulators should require a further artifact, or vendors should make one feasible, is a design and policy question rather than a current examination finding.

3.6 The taxonomic move, summarized

The lending example applies the taxonomy where an artifact exists and regulation specifies a proposition it must support. The pricing turn asks whether the frame also helps where current requirements do not provide an individualized substantive reason-giving artifact for the exact price. It identifies a possible evidentiary and policy gap; it does not classify the regulatory regime itself as having produced the absence or establish that a particular post-hoc artifact is unfaithful.

The remaining sections develop diagnostic techniques for applying this taxonomy (Section 4) and provisional evidentiary capabilities that support those techniques (Section 6). The structural line is an evidentiary constraint: identify the object an artifact exposes and do not infer a different object without an inspectable warrant. Section 7 states the limits on applying that constraint.

4 Diagnostic Techniques

The empty-chair frame produces interpretive structure (Section 2) and a taxonomy of evidentiary claims (Section 3). Across both, documentation, explanation, or approval may be treated as proof of a proposition its artifact does not expose. We call this structure the *evidentiary-substitution sequence*; *silence-manufacture* critically names instances in which unavailable contradictory evidence helps the substitution persist. The three techniques below expose the missing relation and the absent parties who depend on it.

The techniques can be used at several institutional moments. Architects can use them to make evidentiary capabilities explicit; banks can use them to identify compensating controls and procurement needs; examiners can use them to frame requests within existing authority; and regulators can use recurring gaps to inform policy. An affected party or advocate can identify the proposition at stake, supply contradictory evidence, identify an unavailable object, or invoke an existing complaint, appeal, correction, or review pathway. The ontology does not itself create such

a pathway, compel a response, shift a burden, or grant access to protected evidence. Outputs differ because participants do not possess the same authority, capability, access, or standing.

4.1 Silence-manufacture as the underlying structural pattern

The paper joins several established accounts rather than displacing them. Stakeholder theory directs attention to parties whose interests shape an institution's responsibilities, while value-sensitive design asks how human values enter technical design (Freeman 1984; Friedman 1996). Agency theory explains why actors with different interests and information incur monitoring and bonding costs (Jensen and Meckling 1976). Organizational decoupling and audit scholarship explain how formal structures and verification rituals can diverge from operational effect (Meyer and Rowan 1977; Power 1997; Strathern 1997). These traditions already explain affected interests, costly monitoring, information asymmetry, and ceremonial substitution.

Assurance cases already organize claims, supporting argument and evidence, and their context or assumptions (Bloomfield and Bishop 2010). This paper does not discover claims, warrants, or defeaters; it connects assurance reasoning to affected interests, uneven authority and capability, and selected FS AI RMF controls where contradictory evidence may be difficult to observe.

The narrower contribution here is to connect those concerns through an artifact-to-inference sequence in the FS AI RMF setting: an affected interest is translated into a control objective and required evidentiary object; an available artifact is asked to support an inference; a claimed binding is tested; and the gap is assigned to an actor with authority, capability, obligation, or standing to act. This coordination ontology makes it possible to distinguish a current examination question from a policy recommendation and a vendor capability from a bank obligation. *Evidentiary-substitution sequence* is the neutral operational term; *silence-manufacture* is the critical term where unavailable contradictory evidence helps a substitution persist. Neither label alone establishes intention, causation, violation, or legal significance, or covers every information asymmetry or documentation failure.

4.1.1 Definition

We define the **evidentiary-substitution sequence** as follows: a claim requires an evidentiary object that is unavailable; a different artifact is exposed; a broader inference is claimed from it without an inspectable binding; contradictory evidence is unavailable; and an affected party bears the resulting gap. We use **silence-manufacture** as the critical name when the unavailability of contradictory evidence helps that substitution persist. A metric, document, signature, or explanation becomes a substitute only when it is asked to warrant a proposition beyond the object it exposes.

Silence is the *enabling condition*; substitution is the *active mechanism*. The artifact is real. A SHAP value is a real numerical computation. An audit document is a real institutional production. A signed adverse action notice is a real legal instrument. Each can support claims appropriate to it. The sequence begins when an institution treats the artifact as evidence of a different proposition without making the relation inspectable, while system or process conditions leave affected parties unable to produce the evidence that would test that relation. The concept therefore criticizes neither documentation nor explanation as such. It identifies a specific inference gap; the causal claim remains separately testable.

4.1.2 Relationship to Goodhart's law

Silence-manufacture is a complementary pattern to Goodhart's law (Goodhart 1984). The comparison is an orientation device, not a claim of mathematical duality or an extension of Goodhart's result.

Goodhart's law describes optimization pressure on a metric corrupting the metric: when a measure becomes a target, it ceases to be a good measure. The pressure lands on the visible; the visible breaks. Silence-manufacture describes suppression of evidence needed to test the inference drawn from a visible artifact: silence is treated as confirmation even though the architecture helps produce it. The pressure lands on what cannot readily be observed; the artifact appears adequate because the evidence needed to contest its broader use is missing.

Goodhart describes corruption of metrics; silence-manufacture describes an evidentiary substitution that can leave a metric intact. A regulator may improve a visible measure while leaving unchanged the conditions that prevent an affected party from testing what the measure is taken to establish. We return to this possibility below as a proposition generated by the frame, not as a universal law of reform.

4.1.3 Relationship to decoupling and the audit society

Meyer and Rowan's account of decoupling describes formal structures maintained apart from operational activity; Power's audit society and Strathern's account of audit culture describe verification practices that can displace the substance they were meant to secure. The broad phenomenon of an artifact standing in for activity is therefore not new, and we do not claim it is.

The narrower contribution here is a diagnostic sequence. What evidentiary object does a claim require? What feature of law, architecture, interface, method, data, or cost makes that object unavailable? What artifact is offered instead, what inference is drawn from it, and which absent party depends on the inference? This sequence does not presume organizational bad faith or even a coupled alternative that was feasible. It can therefore distinguish ceremonial decoupling from cases in which the relevant silence is legally required, architecturally produced, or methodologically unavoidable.

4.1.4 Mapping the three earned positions onto silence-manufacture

The three positions expose the same evidentiary sequence at different levels, but they do not depend on identical technical mechanisms. Position 1 (governance versus governance theater) is the enclosing institutional frame; Positions 2 and 3 identify particular explanation and accountability failures within it. Their common structure is the inference from an exposed artifact to a proposition that the artifact, without an inspectable binding, does not establish.

Position 2: explanation artifacts do not verify evidentiary objects they do not expose. The relevant limitation depends on the method. SHAP attributes a prediction under a specified feature-coalition formulation; LIME fits a local surrogate around an instance (Lundberg and Lee 2017; Ribeiro et al. 2016). Neither is, without an additional warrant, a transcript of internal computation or a human decision process. Attention weights have likewise been shown not necessarily to support the causal interpretations assigned to them (Jain and Wallace 2019). Chain-of-thought studies provide a different kind of evidence: generated traces can omit influential cues or vary independently of answers in studied settings (Lanham et al. 2023; Turpin et al. 2023). Slack et al. show that post-hoc methods can also be manipulated to conceal biased classifier behavior (Slack et al. 2020). These results do not make the methods interchangeable or useless. They show why the proposition asserted must be matched to the artifact actually produced.

Position 3: review of an explanation is not verification of an unexposed decision process. A signature can establish authorization, completion, and the identity of a reviewer. It supports a stronger claim only when the reviewer had access to evidence capable of testing that claim and the record shows what was tested. Research on sycophancy and evaluator-facing optimization illustrates

why approval signals can diverge from the qualities they are taken to measure (Sharma et al. 2023; Perez et al. 2023); it does not establish that every approval does so. The regulator's question is therefore about reviewer access, competence, and recorded basis, not the mere presence or absence of a signature.

Position 1: governance documentation is evidence of documented commitments and activities, not automatically of operational effect. Policies, inventories, dashboards, and audit records can be indispensable governance artifacts. The inference gap appears when their existence is treated as proof that deployed behavior conforms to them, although the relevant operations were not independently observed or tested. Here again, the remedy is not less documentation but a declared relation between the artifact, the proposition, and the evidence capable of defeating the proposition.

The unification is diagnostic rather than causal. Across the three levels, an examiner can identify the proposition at issue, the available artifact, the claimed binding, and the evidence that could disconfirm it. That common sequence is useful even when the causes of unavailability and the appropriate remedies differ.

4.1.5 What silence-manufacture predicts

The frame suggests three propositions that distinguish it from a generic Goodhart-shaped critique. We state them with observations that would count against them.

Proposition 1: metric-layer reform can leave an inference gap intact. Tighter thresholds, controls, or documentation requirements can improve a visible artifact without making independently testable the broader proposition for which it is used. The proposition would be weakened where metric-only reforms reliably make that broader proposition independently testable, without changes to evidence capture, access, or binding. Section 6 develops architectural responses; Section 7 marks the political-economy assumptions on which adoption depends.

Proposition 2: inquiry can partition around unavailable evidence. Observers with different access may form durable, internally coherent accounts when evidence capable of resolving their disagreement is unavailable. The proposition would be weakened if the disagreement persisted after the relevant evidence became mutually available and its provenance could be tested. More research is not necessarily curative; the diagnostic question is whether the researchers are able to observe the object over which they disagree.

Proposition 3: public narratives can inherit the shape of unavailable evidence. The BSA/AML prohibition on disclosing suspicious-activity reports creates a concrete setting in which customers and outside observers may lack access to an institution's account of a closure (United States Congress 2024). A Reuters complaint review reported by Anthony — 35 of 8,361 account-closure complaints mentioned political or religious motivations — illustrates the need to distinguish a salient narrative from the observed complaint distribution (Anthony 2026); it does not prove what caused every closure or every narrative. The proposition would be weakened if access to the previously unavailable evidence did not materially change the explanations formed by affected parties or public observers.

These are research propositions, not results established by this position paper. Their value is that they identify observations capable of refining or defeating the frame at three sites: regulatory reform, analytical inquiry, and public discourse.

4.2 Three diagnostic techniques

The techniques have two layers. An *orienting question* locates a possible gap; it is not an examination procedure or finding. Where established authority permits inquiry, a structured evidence request

can then test a proposition. The same structure also helps a bank formulate procurement needs, a vendor specify an export, or a regulator identify a recurring policy gap.

4.2.1 Technique 1: Empty-chair enumeration

The orienting question is: *which affected interest depends on this artifact, and what evidence would show that the implementation represents that interest?* The output is a mapping among affected parties, control objectives, evidentiary objects, and the capabilities required to expose them. Conflicting interests remain visible rather than being collapsed into a generic "stakeholder" field.

For a denied applicant, for example, understandability, method fidelity, policy conformity, and access to contest are distinct propositions. An architect can select capabilities against those propositions; a bank can state which are available or compensating; and an examiner can test only those claims within applicable authority.

The mapping is useful precisely when participants disagree. A bank may identify the future compliance officer and the examiner as the principal users of an AI inventory, while an affected customer may depend on the inventory only as an index to case-level evidence. That does not make the inventory useless to the customer or sufficient for the customer's claim. It reveals a chain: the inventory represents organizational accountability directly and supports later retrieval indirectly. The mapping should therefore record both the interest and the proposition, the available artifact, the missing object, and the actor who could supply it. A list of stakeholders without those relations preserves names while losing the governance problem.

Enumeration also exposes conflicts. Detailed evidence access may improve contestability while creating privacy, cybersecurity, suspicious-activity report confidentiality, or intellectual-property risks. The technique does not rank those interests automatically. It requires the institution to identify the conflict, applicable authority, access boundary, and available alternative—for example, protected examiner access, independent validation, aggregation, or a reasoned disclosure that the proposition cannot be tested by the affected party.

4.2.2 Technique 2: Pages missing from the ledger

"Pages missing from the ledger" remains a metaphor for record coverage, not a claim that every event should be attested. Its orienting question is: *which categories lack contemporaneous evidence, relative to what declared scope, and what pattern results?* The operational denominator is a declared attestation scope: the decision universe; category definitions and inclusion or exclusion rules; the rationale and version history for those boundaries; operational counts and risk weighting; reconciliation to system inventories; and both institution-selected and examiner-selected samples.

This denominator matters because raw attestation volume is gameable. An institution could document many low-risk cases while consequential categories remain outside the declared or operational scope. Comparison with operational populations, high-risk categories, boundary changes, inventory records, and externally selected samples makes such curation more expensive. A discrepancy is evidence about coverage. It does not, without additional evidence, prove a motive, violation, or produced-absence mechanism.

Declared scope also needs revision history. If a bank changes a category boundary after adverse cases arise, the new boundary may be reasonable, but a current manifest alone cannot show how the earlier population was treated. Counts before and after the change, the rationale, approval, and reconciliation to operational systems let a reviewer distinguish an ordinary taxonomy repair from unexplained loss of coverage. Risk weighting prevents another collapse: one unattested high-consequence category may matter more than thousands of routine attested events. Institution-

selected samples can demonstrate that a control operates in expected cases; examiner-selected or otherwise external samples test whether the demonstration survives selection outside the institution's curated set.

The output is not a mythical complete ledger. It is an inspectable account of the denominator and its limits. Some categories may remain unattested because capture would be disproportionate, legally restricted, technically unavailable, or dependent on a vendor. Recording that fact and its consequence lets a bank adopt a compensating process or narrow its claim, lets an examiner assess what the existing record warrants, and lets a regulator see whether the same missing capability recurs across institutions.

4.2.3 Technique 3: The produced-silence question pair

The orienting question is: *what access or observability changed, what artifact is offered in its place, and which actor draws what inference from it?* A post-decision justification regime, generic notice, or challenge channel may raise the question. Classification as produced absence still requires the comparative, counterfactual, provenance, or user evidence described in Section 2. Later reflection can add genuine reasoning; the diagnostic asks that it be identified as a later evidentiary object rather than silently substituted for a decision-time record.

The question pair should identify a mechanism and an inference separately. A high complaint cost may reduce observable complaints, but no silence-manufacture sequence exists unless an actor uses the complaint record to support a broader claim. Conversely, an institution may draw an overbroad inference from a sparse record without having caused the sparsity. That is still an artifact-to-inference gap, but not yet produced absence. Separating the two claims prevents the vivid language of suppression from doing empirical work the evidence has not done.

Useful tests follow from the alleged mechanism. If channel friction is the cause, challenge rates or the composition of challengers should change when friction materially changes. If record design overwrites earlier states, version provenance should reveal the loss or an independent source should preserve a different history. If selection is the issue, external sampling or a newly observable population should alter the assessed proposition. Stable behavior, representative records, or unchanged conclusions after access expands count against the produced-absence account. A finding, if any, must still rest on applicable authority and the evidence obtained, not on the orienting label.

4.3 From orientation to evidence request

Each of the three techniques ends in the same place: a question about a specific artifact, a specific proposition, and the relation between them. That question becomes usable when it is written as a request a recipient can answer, refuse, or answer in part with a stated reason. Section 5 gives that form and works one FS AI RMF control objective through it. The remainder of this section concerns what happens when such requests are not made.

4.4 Coordination consequence

The three techniques compound without becoming a checklist. Enumeration says whose interest supplies the purpose; declared scope exposes where records do and do not cover the operational population; and the produced-silence question tests whether the pattern may be endogenous to the process being evaluated. Orientation may lead to an evidence request; evidence may support or defeat an institutional inference; only applicable law or guidance supplies the basis for a formal finding. Unresolved recurring gaps can instead become procurement requirements, vendor design problems, or regulatory policy questions.

Section 6 proposes evidentiary capabilities that could make these requests answerable. Their absence is not automatically a violation, and their presence is not proof that the corresponding governance claim is true.

5 The Evidence Request

The three diagnostics orient inquiry. They become shared work only when they take the form of a specific request that a recipient can answer, refuse, or answer partially with a stated reason. This section gives that form. Nothing in it creates authority. It presumes a requester who already has standing to ask — an examiner under existing examination authority, a bank under its vendor agreement, a regulator under its supervisory process, an affected party under an applicable notice, complaint, appeal, or discovery procedure — and supplies only the structure of the asking.

The structure matters because the common failure is not refusal. It is a responsive-looking answer that addresses a different proposition from the one at issue. A request that names the proposition, the object it requires, and the observations that would defeat it makes that substitution visible.

5.1 The eight fields

An evidence request derived from any of the three diagnostics should state eight fields compactly. Stated as a request rather than a description:

1. **Authority.** We are asking under [statute, regulation, enforceable condition, contractual provision, or adopted internal policy]. Supervisory guidance, where cited, informs the analysis and is not offered as the obligation: agency rules codifying the role of supervisory guidance provide that guidance does not carry the force and effect of law and is not by itself a basis for supervisory criticism. Identify any respect in which you contest the stated basis.

2. **Proposition.** We are testing whether [the specific claim]. This is the proposition at issue; responses addressing a different claim should say so.

3. **Required object.** Establishing that proposition requires evidence of [decision-time inputs and context / functional feature dependence / local behavioral approximation / internal computational state / a generated rationale / a human deliberative record / institutional authorization]. State which object you take the proposition to require if you disagree.

4. **Offered artifact.** Identify the artifact you offer as establishing it, and the object that artifact exposes.

5. **Binding records.** Provide the operative model and case binding, method and configuration, background-data construction, feature handling, software version, generation provenance, stability and relevant validation tests, known limitations, declared attestation scope, and reviewer access.

6. **Defeating observations.** Identify the observations that would support the proposition and those that would defeat it. If no available observation could defeat it, say so.

7. **Ownership.** Identify the party able to close or disclose any gap — institution, vendor, or neither — and the remedy available to the party whose interest the gap falls on.

8. **Disposition.** State whether the result bears on a current finding, on an assessment of a claimed inference, or on a policy or design question outside the present review.

Field 6 carries unusual weight. An artifact that no available observation could have contradicted establishes that a process was run, not that its conclusion holds. A validation regime with no failing condition, or a monitoring report with no threshold that triggers action, answers fields 1 through 5 completely and field 6 not at all.

5.2 A worked request

Consider FS AI RMF objective MS-2.9.1, which calls for structured model explanations and method documentation, with validation for matters including stability, performance, fairness, bias, and limitations. A bank offers a SHAP report in support of the proposition that stated principal reasons are faithful to a particular model output. The required object is method-specific functional attribution under a declared value function and background construction; it is not a transcript of model reasoning, and the report does not become one by being called an explanation.

The request accordingly seeks the operative model and case binding, the value function, the background-data construction, feature handling, software version, generation provenance, stability and relevant validation tests, known limitations, and reviewer access. Stable, reproducible attributions under the declared construction, agreeing with suitable model-specific tests, support the proposition. Instability, broken provenance, or material sensitivity to an unjustified background defeats the broader claim while leaving the narrower one intact.

The disposition then divides by actor. The bank can narrow its stated claim to the bounded warrant the artifact supports, adopt a compensating control, or disclose the residual gap. The vendor may be the only party able to supply the missing provenance or export. An examiner may assess whether the bank's claimed inference is supported, under authority the examiner already holds, without prescribing any particular explanation architecture — the objective does not authorize a finding that one architecture was required. An affected party, where a notice, complaint, appeal, or discovery process applies, can ask which method produced the stated reasons and what binds that output to their own file, rather than asking the institution to explain the denial.

That last division is the point of the form. The same eight fields, answered once, tell four differently situated parties four different things they can each act on separately.

6 Provisional Evidentiary Capabilities

The diagnostics in Section 4 generate five provisional evidentiary capabilities. They are design hypotheses, not universal requirements or a complete governance architecture. A capability may be supplied by a vendor product, a bank-controlled system, a contractually required export, an independent assessment, or a compensating process. The institution remains responsible for claims it makes with vendor-supported evidence, but responsibility does not imply unilateral power to alter the vendor's system.

Each capability is stated by the object it should expose and the limit on what that object establishes. An examiner need not personally perform cryptographic verification or model forensics: the review may inspect bank or third-party validation, provenance, controls, and selected underlying evidence. Which pathway is proportionate depends on the claim, risk, authority, and available implementation.

6.1 Capability 1: Revision-aware temporal capture

The first capability preserves distinct, time-bound records rather than a single mutable narrative. Its decision-time record captures the inputs and context presented, observable actions, stated uncertainties, and provisional reasons. Later records may add reflective interpretation or newly discovered reasons; still later records may authorize, correct, or reassess the decision under policy. Each layer carries its own timestamp, provenance, and binding to the decision and prior record. Later reflection may contribute genuine understanding, but it must not overwrite or impersonate the earlier account.

Tamper-evident commitments, controlled audit logs, signed records, or independently maintained timestamps are possible implementations. A bank may operate them or contract for them. An examiner can inspect validation of the binding and selected records rather than reproduce the mechanism. Temporal capture establishes when specified content was committed and whether revision is detectable; it does not establish that the content was true, complete, or a transparent account of human cognition.

Validation should therefore test the entire record lifecycle rather than the timestamp alone. It can sample whether material inputs and system versions are captured before disposition, whether later annotations create new records rather than mutate old ones, whether clock and identity controls are reliable, and whether retention and migration preserve verification. A cryptographically strong commitment to an incomplete field set remains incomplete; a detailed record written after the event remains retrospective. The capability is useful because it keeps those limitations visible while allowing reflection to remain part of governance rather than treating every later reason as suspect.

6.2 Capability 2: Evidence binding and exportability

The second capability makes a declared relationship among a decision, artifact, method, model and data versions, policy, review, and authorization traversable. Inspection should be possible backward from a decision to its supporting material and, where appropriate, forward from material to affected decisions. The export must preserve identifiers, provenance, configurations, and relevant validation rather than reduce the relationship to a product dashboard.

This is particularly important for community banks using vendor-controlled systems. A bank remains responsible for ensuring that evidence warrants the claims it makes, but it may be unable to obtain that evidence through a standard product or contract. A vendor may provide a structured export; a bank may maintain external bindings; an independent assessor may validate proprietary components; or a compensating process may narrow the claim or reduce risk. Sometimes no proportionate substitute exists. Product access without inspectable evidence leaves a residual gap rather than creating procurement leverage.

Binding an explanation to a decision establishes association and provenance. It does not prove causal influence, method fidelity, or evidentiary sufficiency. Those are separate propositions tested with method-appropriate evidence.

Exportability is also an access property, not merely a file-format property. An export that only the vendor can interpret, omits model or configuration versions, cannot be reconciled to the bank's decision population, or expires before the applicable retention period may be technically portable but evidentially unusable. Contracts can specify schemas, identifiers, retention, change notice, validation access, and transition assistance; independent assessment can protect proprietary details while testing a bounded claim. These arrangements do not remove third-party risk. They make the evidence dependency and the residual limitation explicit enough for bank governance and regulatory review.

6.3 Capability 3: Non-collapsing uncertainty representation

The third capability preserves materially different reasons for uncertainty instead of forcing them into one probability or confidence label. Depending on the decision, a useful representation may distinguish supporting evidence, counterevidence, conflict among sources, model or measurement uncertainty, missing information, and ambiguity about applicable policy. A single value can be well calibrated for one target while remaining silent about which of these conditions produced it.

The paper does not prescribe a fixed number of dimensions or one mathematical formalism. A structured record, interval, set-valued output, qualitative state, or combination may be appropriate. The functional test is whether material support, counterevidence, conflict, and insufficiency survive reporting and can be bound to the resulting action. Vendors may expose native uncertainty and provenance; banks must decide how policy treats the represented state; and validation should test whether the representation is stable, meaningful, and used as declared. The representation does not itself establish that the underlying evidence is accurate.

The policy interface is as important as the representation. A system might faithfully report conflict or missing information while a workflow treats every non-numeric state as approval, routes it around human review, or silently converts it to a midpoint. Validation should trace representative and high-consequence states through display, reviewer action, override, escalation, and final disposition. It should also test whether different uncertainty types are comprehensible to their intended users. The goal is not maximal complexity; it is to preserve distinctions that would change a reasonable action or the claim made about that action.

6.4 Capability 4: Technical-change monitoring

Technical-change monitoring asks whether the empirical system has changed. Relevant objects include input distributions, relationships between inputs and targets, measured performance, calibration, subgroup behavior, and the model or data pipeline itself. Data-drift tests, concept-drift analysis, outcome monitoring, version comparison, and targeted validation answer different questions; no shared detector is presumed.

The likely implementation path combines vendor telemetry and change notices with bank or third-party validation against the institution's operational population. Examiners can inspect the monitoring design, thresholds, escalation records, and selected results. A detected change directs investigation; it does not establish cause, harm, or noncompliance.

The declared population and outcome lag matter. Aggregate stability may conceal subgroup change, while a small subgroup can produce noisy alarms. Ground truth may arrive months after a credit or fraud decision, and interventions may alter the outcomes used for validation. Monitoring should therefore state its unit of analysis, reference population, windows, missing-outcome treatment, subgroup coverage, thresholds, and escalation logic. A vendor's global performance dashboard can inform this work but cannot automatically establish performance for one bank's customers, configuration, or operational use.

6.5 Capability 5: Institutional-conformance monitoring

Institutional-conformance monitoring asks a different question: whether operational practice continues to match declared policy, authority, and control design. Its evidence includes workflow and override records, access and authorization histories, exceptions, complaints, sampled case files, attestation-scope reconciliation, and changes in policy interpretation. Statistical drift may be absent while practice diverges from policy, or present while practice remains conformant.

The bank ordinarily owns the policy relationship, while vendors must expose the events and configurations needed to test it. Internal audit, compliance, independent review, affected-party evidence, and examiner-selected samples can challenge a self-selected institutional account. A discrepancy establishes a conformance question and may support a finding where applicable authority and evidence do so; the monitoring capability alone does not determine legal significance.

Conformance evidence is vulnerable to the same selection problem as other governance artifacts. A dashboard built entirely from events the workflow was configured to emit can show perfect compliance while uninstrumented exceptions remain outside its denominator. Reconciliation to inventories, permissions, complaints, manual queues, downstream systems, and external samples tests that boundary. Because policy can change legitimately, monitoring must preserve the operative policy version and authority at the time of action rather than judge every historical case by the latest text. Technical and institutional monitoring can inform one another, but neither is a substitute for the other.

6.6 What the capabilities contribute

Together, the five capabilities can make the diagnostics answerable: revision-aware capture preserves temporal layers; binding and exportability make declared relations inspectable; non-collapsing representation preserves the kind of uncertainty at issue; and the two monitoring capabilities distinguish technical change from institutional divergence. Multiple coherent implementations may exist, and a compensating process may sometimes provide the required evidence more proportionately than new infrastructure.

Their presence does not establish that every affected interest is represented, and their absence does not prove that representation is impossible. Cost, security, confidentiality, records law, and vendor leverage constrain the design space. The practical question is whether a proposed implementation makes the relevant artifact-to-inference relation more inspectable at a proportionate cost. That question remains empirical.

No universal sequence among the five capabilities follows from the frame. Priority depends on the proposition at risk, applicable obligations, existing evidence, consequence and likelihood, vendor dependence, and feasible alternatives. When no implementation or compensating process makes a material claim supportable, risk acceptance, restricted use, replacement, or discontinuation are institution-specific governance decisions rather than technical outputs prescribed by this paper.

7 Honest Uncertainties

The preceding sections bound their claims where they arise. This section does not retract those claims. It collects the remaining uncertainties that matter to a regulator, architect, or examiner deciding how to use the frame.

7.1 Scope of the frame

Empty-chair enumeration and weighting remain open. The six chairs in the BSA/AML example are illustrative, not exhaustive. Practitioners may identify different affected parties or assign different weight to their interests. The frame contributes a discipline—name the absent party, the interest at stake, and the evidence of representation—but it does not supply a complete roster or a weighting rule. Disagreement is most useful when those choices are made explicit and can themselves be examined.

Structural and produced absence may not exhaust the possibilities. Some absences are mixed, and practice may reveal additional categories. The distinction is useful where it changes the diagnostic response: a structural absence may require representation or a proxy, while a produced absence calls for scrutiny of the design that produced it and the inference drawn from it. The paper does not claim that every case fits cleanly into one category.

Generalization is limited to the contexts examined. The paper develops the frame through community-banking examples in BSA/AML monitoring, lending, and pricing. Application to insurance, healthcare, criminal justice, or social services is a research proposition, not a result. Even within finance, evidence that a mechanism appears on one dataset or product does not establish transfer to another. Sectoral use should begin with new empty-chair enumeration, legal analysis, and validation of the relevant evidentiary relationships rather than directly importing the examples here.

7.2 Conditions of examination

Adversarial and cooperative settings differ. Examination includes both: an examiner may test a claim against an institution's incentives, and the same parties may cooperate to resolve a shared safety or compliance problem. The paper's strongest warnings about explanation and self-verification concern settings where incentives are opposed or where a claim must survive challenge. In cooperative settings, explanation artifacts can support discovery and communication even when they would not independently verify the proposition at issue. The method and claimed inference should therefore be evaluated in the actual examination context.

Application requires resources and coordination. The three diagnostic questions demand time, expertise, access, and institutional support. Not every examiner can apply them to every system, and a sophisticated institution can design formally compliant artifacts that remain difficult to interrogate. Their practical effect may depend less on exhaustive case-by-case use than on making the questions predictable enough that institutions design systems able to answer them. This paper does not establish whether supervisory organizations can provide the necessary capacity or coordinate a consistent practice.

Affected-party access is not uniform. The ontology gives affected interests standing in the analysis; it does not imply that every affected party can or should inspect every artifact. Suspicious-activity confidentiality, personal data, cybersecurity controls, trade secrets, and the rights of other customers can limit direct disclosure. Representation may therefore travel through several contest pathways: a customer-facing explanation and correction process, protected access for an examiner, independent testing of a proprietary method, aggregate reporting, or an advocate with appropriate standing. These pathways are not equivalent. Independent validation can test a bounded proposition while leaving the affected party unable to identify an error in their own case; a clear notice can enable challenge while revealing little about population-level behavior. Applying the frame requires stating who can access which object, what proposition that access permits them to test, and which unresolved interest remains represented only indirectly. Whether a particular access restriction is justified is a legal, security, and proportionality question outside the ontology itself.

Representation is not participation or remedy. Indirect inspection by an examiner or independent assessor may represent an affected interest in an evidentiary inquiry while leaving the affected person without direct voice, access, or relief. Existing complaint, appeal, correction, and review processes may permit participation or contest, but this paper neither creates those processes nor establishes when law should require them. Where none exists, the ontology can make the absent pathway, the institution able to create it, and the party bearing its absence legible. That diagnosis

is not itself a remedy.

7.3 Architectural boundaries

The five capabilities are provisional and non-exhaustive. Revision-aware temporal capture, evidence binding and exportability, non-collapsing uncertainty representation, technical-change monitoring, and institutional-conformance monitoring are generated by this frame's diagnostics. They are neither a complete governance architecture nor proven necessary for every deployment. Alternative technical, contractual, independent-assessment, or compensating-process implementations may answer a diagnostic question more simply. Implementation may also reveal additional needs.

Operational tractability is unproven. The capabilities may impose storage, integration, validation, and review costs. Those costs may be material for a community bank and may interact with confidentiality, retention, cybersecurity, and vendor constraints. Banks remain responsible for their claims but may lack leverage to obtain evidence from core-system and AI vendors. The paper has not built or evaluated a complete implementation, compared alternatives, or shown that benefits justify costs. The capabilities are design hypotheses with explicit evidentiary functions, not an implementation mandate.

Vendor dependence creates a two-level theory of effect. A community bank may identify an evidence gap correctly and still be unable to alter a core platform, obtain method provenance, or negotiate a bespoke export. Large vendors can spread implementation cost across institutions, but they also choose product roadmaps and contractual defaults under incentives different from those of one bank, examiner, or affected customer. One bank can make the dependency visible, narrow its claim, evaluate available processes, and record the residual risk. The collective pathway aggregates those limits: examiners identify unsupported claims within current authority; regulators and trade groups observe recurrence; and vendors receive a more consistent capability signal. This paper does not establish that collective signals will overcome switching costs, concentration, proprietary constraints, or fragmented regulatory expectations.

Nor does vendor implementation end the inquiry. A standardized export may omit locally material context; independent validation may be too narrow or too expensive; a compensating process may shift work to already constrained bank staff. Confidentiality and cybersecurity can also justify limiting access that would otherwise improve contestability. The relevant comparison is among feasible evidence pathways and their residual gaps, not between perfect access and presumed noncompliance.

7.4 Who moves first

The largest uncertainty is not whether any participant would find the frame useful. It is that each participant's first move appears to depend on another's. A community bank converting silent gaps into written disclosures before an examination has reason to want evidence that examiners will treat a disclosed gap with a compensating process as adequate posture rather than as a self-reported finding. A vendor asked to fund an evidence-export capability has reason to want evidence that examiners are issuing requests in this shape, since capability purchases follow examinations that institutions could not answer. An examiner has authority to test a claimed inference but must be able to name the statute, regulation, or supervisory expectation under which each evidentiary object may be compelled, and to state what may be supportably concluded when an institution answers that the object is vendor-proprietary and unavailable. A regulator considering guidance must demonstrate workability for a small institution, which requires evidence about burden that only institutional use would generate.

Those four dependencies form a cycle. The paper cannot resolve it by asserting that collective action will aggregate individual practice; that assertion is what the cycle calls into question.

Two artifacts would break it, and neither requires any participant to act first. The first is an authority crosswalk: for each evidentiary object this paper names, the existing authority under which its production may be sought, and the inference available when it is withheld as proprietary. The second is a mapping from selected FS AI RMF control objectives to the records a conforming institution would necessarily hold, which would let a party without discovery request documents by name rather than by description. Both are desk work against existing law, guidance, and the framework text. Neither is supplied here. Their absence is the most consequential gap in this paper, and it is a gap in this paper rather than in the coordination problem it describes.

A preliminary attempt at the first suggests the crosswalk will not divide the objects into compellable and non-compellable. Supervisory authority is not confined to inspecting records that happen to exist: reporting powers can require statements and special reports prepared on demand, recordkeeping regulation can mandate that records be generated prospectively, and an examiner's own analysis of produced data is the examiner's work product rather than something compelled from the institution. The line that does hold is narrower and concerns time. An institution can be required to answer for a missing record, to prepare a report, or to build a prospective control. It cannot be required to produce, after the fact, an object that would exist only if the decision process had preserved it contemporaneously.

That line cuts through the objects unevenly. Feature attributions, local approximations, and internal-state observations are in principle recomputable later. What is not recomputable is the binding: which model version and configuration, under which policy, actually produced a particular decision on a particular file. Where that binding was not captured at decision time, the recomputable objects lose their referent, and the question of whether they could have been compelled becomes moot — there is nothing to compel them against. Decision-time context and the record of what a human reviewer was actually shown are subject to the same limit and have no recomputable substitute at all.

The practical consequence is that one narrow record carries most of the weight, and the precedent for creating it already exists. Mandated loan-level reporting under the Home Mortgage Disclosure Act did not ask institutions to surrender data they happened to hold; it required the record to be generated so that oversight would have something to examine. A comparable and considerably smaller requirement — that a decision record bind to the operative model version, configuration, and policy in force at decision time — is the smallest change that would convert several currently unreachable objects into reachable ones. This paper does not propose that rule, and identifying the smallest sufficient rule is not the same as establishing that it should be adopted.

A third artifact would do more and cannot be produced at a desk: one worked execution of the evidence request of Section 5 at an actual institution, recording which fields were answerable from records the bank held, which required a compensating process, which were unanswerable because a vendor controlled the evidence, and what the exercise cost in staff hours. That single exhibit is what a regulator would need for a workability finding and what a vendor would need for a demand signal.

7.4.1 An illustrative voluntary pathway

One possible institutional execution would change the incentives around that first move without requiring every institution to adopt the same modeling paradigm. An institution seeking a bounded procedural benefit could commit its policy, the ontology that gives the policy operational meaning, and the rule by which an eventual model would be selected. An authorized reviewer could object, request clarification, or accept that package before construction begins. The reviewer could then

assign a qualified independent constructor through an auditable process while withholding the constructor's identity from the institution and, so far as the required facts permit, the institution's identity from the constructor. Questions would return through the reviewer rather than becoming private negotiation between institution and implementer. Both parties would remain identifiable and accountable to the reviewer.

Where several policy-conforming models perform similarly but disagree about individual cases, the constructor should not silently decide which one becomes the institution's model. A stronger record would preserve a reproducibly generated representation of those alternatives, independent evaluation of their material differences, and application of the selection rule committed before the alternatives and their effects were known. The constructor's role could end with delivery of the portable candidate package and its construction evidence. After rule-bound selection, deployment by the institution or a separate integrator would require a further binding showing that the deployed system is the selected artifact or differs only through permitted transformations.

A regulator could, as a policy choice, attach a rebuttable evidentiary presumption or streamlined review of specified process questions to use of such a pathway. That consequence would motivate participation; it is not a property the technical protocol can create. The ordinary path would remain available to an institution that develops its own model, without the special presumption and without relief from otherwise applicable review. If individualized participation proved expensive, reviewed baseline policies and ontologies with constrained institution-specific elections might emerge for smaller institutions. Such packages could lower fixed cost, but could also create monoculture, conceal locally material differences, or turn a reviewed default into ceremonial compliance. This paper neither proposes such a safe harbor nor establishes the authority, workability, or desirability of one.

The warrant would in any event remain narrow. Blinded assignment can reduce the opportunity for an institution and constructor to coordinate on a preferred implementation; precommitment can expose retrospective changes and unrecorded selection discretion. Neither establishes that the original policy or ontology is nondiscriminatory or was adopted in good faith. A pretextual choice may be committed early and executed faithfully. Nor does pseudonymization guarantee that institutional details cannot reveal identity, eliminate collusion outside the process, establish that a sampled set contains every material alternative, or prove that later deployment preserved the reviewed behavior. The pathway is therefore an example of how the ontology could bind actors and artifacts across an institutional boundary, not a fairness certificate or substitute for substantive review.

7.5 Theory of effect

The paper assumes that clearer evidentiary distinctions can change what architects preserve, what institutions claim, and what examiners ask. That effect is plausible but unproven. Regulatory practice may instead stabilize around easier documentary proxies; institutions may lack the authority or resources to change vendor systems; or the vocabulary may be adopted without the discipline it names. Coordination may produce another dashboard while leaving underlying evidence inaccessible. Conversely, the frame may be useful even without formal adoption if it helps one regulator identify an unsupported inference or one architect preserve evidence that would otherwise disappear.

Adoption can fail by ceremonial compliance as well as rejection. Participants might add "affected party," "binding," or "indeterminacy" fields to a template while leaving the underlying artifact, access, and decision process unchanged. Counts of completed fields would then measure use of the vocabulary, not its effect. Evaluation should instead sample whether a claimed inference can be traversed to its evidence, whether defeating observations are genuinely available, whether declared

scope reconciles to operational populations, and whether identified gaps change a decision, disclosure, procurement request, or policy analysis. Even those observations do not isolate causation without a comparison, but they are closer to the proposed theory of effect than document production alone.

The appropriate test is practical and revisable: do the diagnostics reveal material inference gaps, do the proposed properties make those gaps more inspectable, and do affected parties receive better representation as a result? Evidence against any link should narrow or change the frame. This position paper offers the questions and provisional capabilities; it does not claim the outcomes of their adoption.

8 Conclusion

The FS AI RMF gives financial institutions a substantial control vocabulary (U.S. Department of the Treasury 2026). It does not, by itself, tell a community bank how those controls cohere, tell an examiner what a completed artifact warrants, or give either participant leverage to obtain missing evidence from a vendor. Empty-chair representation supplies a coordination ontology for that gap. It traces an affected interest through the control objective, required evidentiary object, offered artifact, claimed inference and binding, and the actor able to close, disclose, or contest the difference.

This is procedural neutrality rather than a view from nowhere. Affected parties remain the normative center although they do not have power symmetric with a bank, vendor, or regulator. Banks, examiners, regulators, and vendors receive distinct roles because their obligations, authority, and capabilities differ. The ontology makes those differences discussable without resolving them by terminology. Evidentiary representation does not itself grant an affected party access, participation, contest rights, or remedy.

The central constraint is that artifacts retain their method-specific warrants. Decision-time records, feature attributions, local approximations, internal-state observations, generated rationales, later reflective accounts, human review records, and institutional approvals may all be useful. They expose different evidentiary objects. An explanation reviewed by a human establishes that the explanation was reviewed; a stronger conclusion depends on what the method targets, what the reviewer could test, and how the evidence is bound to the claim. Later reflection may discover genuine reasons, but should be preserved as later reflection rather than substituted for a decision-time record.

One consequence of that constraint deserves restatement, because it inverts a common assumption about what can be recovered later. Feature attributions, local approximations, and internal-state observations are in principle recomputable after the fact; the binding — which model version and configuration, under which policy in force, produced this decision on this file — is not. Where that binding was not captured contemporaneously, the recomputable artifacts lose their referent, and decision-time context and the record of what a reviewer was shown have no substitute at all (Section 7.4). One narrow decision-time record therefore carries most of the weight of future verifiability, and mandated generation of a record so that oversight has something to examine has precedent in loan-level reporting under the Home Mortgage Disclosure Act. Identifying that smallest sufficient record is not the same as establishing that it should be required; the observation is that without it, most of the evidentiary objects this paper names become unreachable in retrospect.

The neutral diagnostic structure is an evidentiary-substitution sequence. Silence-manufacture names instances in which unavailable contradictory evidence helps the substitution persist; it does not presume bad faith: a required evidentiary object is unavailable, another artifact is offered, a broader inference is claimed without an inspectable binding, contradictory evidence is unavailable, and an

affected party bears the gap. Produced absence is likewise a hypothesis. Observed silence alone does not establish that a design or institution caused it; comparison, counterfactual, provenance, user, complaint, or externally sampled evidence must test the proposed mechanism.

The three diagnostics translate these distinctions into shared work. Empty-chair enumeration identifies which interest depends on an artifact. Pages missing from the ledger compares record coverage with a declared attestation scope and operational population. The produced-silence question asks what changed observability and who draws which inference from the resulting record. Each begins as orientation. Under established authority it can structure an evidence request; with sufficient evidence, and a statute, regulation, enforceable condition, or adequately grounded safety-and-soundness determination, it may contribute to a finding. Supervisory guidance may inform that analysis but does not supply the obligation. Otherwise, the result may properly remain a disclosed limitation, procurement need, vendor design problem, or policy question.

That division gives each participant a usable handoff. One bank can say which proposition it is responsible for, which evidence it possesses, which available process narrows the gap, which residual limitation remains, and which export it needs from a vendor. That clarity does not give the bank bargaining power it lacks. An examiner can test a claimed inference without prescribing an unrequired architecture. A regulator can aggregate recurring gaps and decide whether guidance, coordinated expectations, or no further action is warranted. A vendor can specify which provenance, exportability, temporal, uncertainty, and monitoring capabilities its system supplies. Cross-vendor bindings, standard exports, and market leverage require coordinated infrastructure that no single institution can produce. An affected party can identify the interest and proposition at stake, supply evidence, and invoke any applicable complaint, appeal, correction, or review process. Where no such pathway exists, the ontology identifies the absence and who bears it; it does not cure the absence by calling the interest represented.

For a participant reading or contesting an AI governance record, the frame reduces to five questions:

1. What evidentiary object does this artifact expose?
2. What proposition is the institution asking the recipient to infer?
3. What inspectable binding warrants that inference?
4. Whose interest bears the gap, and under what authority may it be tested?
5. Which actor can close or disclose the gap, through what authorized action?

Those questions do not, by themselves, decide every governance dispute or create authority that law and policy have not supplied. They make the location and ownership of disagreement legible. A useful governance architecture should let an affected party's interest appear not only in policy language, but in evidence capable of bearing the conclusion placed upon it.

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